Bills API — User Guide

For: approved PWMS partner applications (for example, the Main Website) **Scope:** read-only access to the parliamentary bills register **API version:** `/api/v1/`

> **Printable one-page version:** Bills API User Guide (PDF). This Markdown file is the longer editable version; the one-page handout is generated from the HTML source.

This guide shows how to obtain a token and retrieve bills. You cannot create, edit or delete bills through this API.

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1. What you need

Your PWMS administrator will give you:

- the PWMS base address, e.g. `https://workflows-dev.parliament.gov.za`
- a **client ID**
- a **client secret**
- the **`bills:read`** scope

Keep the client secret private. If it is exposed, ask the administrator to rotate it.

The interactive reference — including every field — is at `/api/v1/docs` on the PWMS host.

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2. Get an access token

```
curl -s -X POST "https://pwms.example.gov.za/api/v1/auth/token/" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{"client_id": "YOUR_CLIENT_ID", "client_secret": "YOUR_SECRET"}'
```

```
{
  "access_token": "eyJ…",
  "refresh_token": "8fK…",
  "token_type": "Bearer",
  "expires_in": 900,
  "refresh_expires_in": 86400,
  "scope": "bills:read"
}
```

- **Access token** — valid for **15 minutes**. Send it with every request.
- **Refresh token** — valid for **24 hours**, single use. Exchange it for a new pair before it expires (or when a call returns `401`):

```
curl -s -X POST "https://pwms.example.gov.za/api/v1/auth/token/refresh/" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{"refresh_token": "YOUR_REFRESH_TOKEN"}'
```

A refresh token that has expired or already been used cannot be replayed; obtain a new token pair with your client ID and secret.

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3. Endpoints

Method	Path	Purpose
GET	`/api/v1/bills/`	List and search bills
GET	`/api/v1/bills/{public_id}/`	One bill by its `public_id`

Method	Path	Purpose
GET	/api/v1/search/	Search bills together with any other resources your key may read
GET	/api/v1/me/	Check your client ID and scopes

Every request needs:

```
Authorization: Bearer <access_token>
```

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4. List and filter bills

```
curl -sG "https://pwms.example.gov.za/api/v1/bills/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $ACCESS_TOKEN" \
  --data-urlencode "limit=20" \
  --data-urlencode "offset=0"
```

Filter	What it does	Examples
search	Searches all text fields below (case-insensitive substring)	search=appropriation
search_fields	Limits search to chosen fields; comma-separated	search_fields=title,short_title
bill_type	Bill classification	section-74, section-75, section-76, section-77
house_of_origin	House of introduction	na, ncop
public_status	Citizen-facing status; slug or exact name	introduced, Under Parliamentary Consideration
responsible_committee	Committee; public_id, name, short name or slug	Portfolio Committee on Health
ordering	Sort order; prefix with - to reverse	-introduced_date, bill_number, title
limit	Page size (default 20, maximum 100)	limit=50
offset	Number of records to skip	offset=50

Searchable fields for `search_fields`: bill_number, title, short_title, description, sponsor_name, responsible_committee, atc_reference, order_paper_reference, public_status.

Example: bills of a type and status

```
curl -sG "https://pwms.example.gov.za/api/v1/bills/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $ACCESS_TOKEN" \
  --data-urlencode "bill_type=section-76" \
  --data-urlencode "public_status=Under Parliamentary Consideration" \
  --data-urlencode "ordering=-introduced_date"
```

Example: bills for a committee

```
curl -sG "https://pwms.example.gov.za/api/v1/bills/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $ACCESS_TOKEN" \
  --data-urlencode "responsible_committee=Portfolio Committee on Health"
```

> Use `curl -G --data-urlencode` (or your HTTP library's query-parameter support) for names containing spaces or punctuation.

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5. Read one bill

```
curl -s "https://pwms.example.gov.za/api/v1/bills/0192f3c0-7a1e-7c2b-9d4e-1a2b3c4d5e6f/" \
```

```
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $ACCESS_TOKEN"
```

Use the bill's `public_id` (a UUID), not an internal database id.

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6. Pages and results

Every list response is a page:

```
{
  "count": 42,
  "limit": 20,
  "offset": 0,
  "next": "https://…/api/v1/bills/?limit=20&offset=20",
  "previous": null,
  "results": [ { … }, { … } ]
}
```

`count` is the total number of matching bills. Follow `next` until it is `null` to read the whole result set; `previous` goes back one page. The links preserve your search and filters.

A bill in `results` includes:

`public_id`, `bill_number`, `title`, `short_title`, `description`, `bill_type`, `house_of_origin`, `sponsor` / `sponsor_name`, `introduced_date`, `responsible_committee`, `atc_reference`, `order_paper_reference`, `bill_document_url`, `public_status`, `current_version`, `identifier`, `is_overdue`, `deadline`, `priority`, `created_at` and `updated_at`.

`public_status` is the citizen-facing status. `current_version` is the label of the current bill version. Dates are ISO 8601; fields that have no value are `null` or an empty string.

Combined search

If you also have access to other registers, search bills and the other resources in one call:

```
curl -sG "https://pwms.example.gov.za/api/v1/search/" \
  -H "Authorization: Bearer $ACCESS_TOKEN" \
  --data-urlencode "q=appropriation" \
  --data-urlencode "resources=bills" \
  --data-urlencode "limit=10" \
  --data-urlencode "offset=0"
```

The `bills` group in the response is a page with the same `count`, `limit`, `offset`, `next`, `previous` and `results` shape.

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7. Common responses

Status	Meaning	What to do
`200`	Success	—
`400`	Invalid parameter (e.g. unknown `search_fields`, `q` too short)	Correct the request
`401`	Missing, expired or invalid access token	Refresh, or obtain a new token pair
`403`	Your key does not have `bills:read`	Contact the PWMS administrator
`404`	No bill with that `public_id`	Check the id
`429`	Rate limit exceeded	Wait for the `Retry-After` time, then retry

Each key has a requests-per-minute limit (60 by default; your registration may differ). The token endpoint is separately limited to 20 requests per minute per IP address.

8. Practical tips

- Refresh the access token before it expires (for example after 12 minutes) rather than waiting for a `401`.
- Cache a response only while it is still useful; bills change over time.
- Use `limit` values you actually need — 20–50 keeps responses fast.
- Send `public_id` values exactly as returned; they are case-sensitive.
- Contact the PWMS administrator if a bill appears in PWMS but not through the API, or if you need an additional scope.

Support: PWMS administrator — see the contact details supplied with your client credentials.